Ukraine: Ceasefire odds increase in second quarter

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November’s trilateral talks among Russia, Ukraine, and the US on ending the war in Ukraine will remain largely technical and not deliver any political breakthroughs, as both sides escalate their military campaigns through the end of the first quarter of next year.
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After that escalatory cycle plays out, a window will open for substantive talks in the second quarter; that raises the odds of a ceasefire to 35% through the end of 2027, from 10% now, and leaves a 65% chance that the war will continue.
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The odds of a ceasefire are rising because Western support for Kyiv will likely face its greatest strain just as serious talks become more plausible: US support is fickle and, for the first time, a Marine Le Pen presidency could undermine European aid, sanctions, and Kyiv’s accession process.

Russia and Ukraine’s escalation cycle will last through at least the first quarter of 2027. November's trilateral talks are likely to progress only on technical issues. As in February, when the talks yielded only a prisoner exchange, both sides' substantive demands remain irreconcilable (see: Escalation likely precludes Russia-Ukraine ceasefire talks through spring 2027 , 11 September 2026).

Russia's demands will remain maximalist. On 22 October, President Vladimir Putin agreed to resume talks but insisted that Russia must achieve all its objectives. Moscow has since moderated somewhat: It no longer demands the full lifting of sanctions, accepting their gradual easing instead, and appears to be more willing to talk to Kyiv directly. Yet this mild moderation falls well short of what serious talks would require. Putin believes time is once again on his side and is unwilling to make significant concessions for now. Russia’s economy is in bad shape but stable enough to let him wait: The deficit will approach 3% of GDP this year, and the civilian economy is near recession, yet reserves and costlier borrowing mean Putin does not have to change his war policy yet. He is also betting that winter will break Ukrainian morale and that a Le Pen victory in France’s presidential election—our basecase (40% odds)—will erode European support.

Ukraine also remains unlikely to offer significant concessions before April 2027. Coverage of the war has grown more pessimistic again after a summer of positive headlines. Yet the situation on the battlefield is

largely unchanged; Ukraine is making small gains at the front, and a Russian breakthrough remains very unlikely. In the air, Ukraine continues hitting Russian targets despite US pressure. US policy will keep zigzagging, but not enough to force Kyiv to change strategy (see: Diplomatic fallout with Ukraine will persist beyond intelligence-sharing resumption , 29 October 2026).

A difficult winter is unlikely to force Ukraine to concede, but fragmenting EU support might. The public does not yet feel compelled to surrender to Russian demands. In a Kyiv International Institute of Sociology (KIIS) poll from 8–16 October, 61% called withdrawing from Ukrainian-held Donbas unacceptable, even in exchange for security guarantees, while 35% would accept it. Some 62% are ready to endure the war as long as necessary. Many Ukrainians are prepared to adapt to power outages or move to the countryside if life in large cities becomes unbearable.

Calls from fringe politicians for peace at the price of political concessions have found little support and been seen as betrayal by some: MP Oleksiy Goncharenko was expelled from his party's faction a day after floating neutrality and minority-language status for Russian. Only 20% of Ukrainians think the authorities should be more accommodating in negotiations, while 73% disagree (KIIS). The appeal of a deal will likely grow through the winter, but the mainstream view is unlikely to change as Russia's conduct of the war continues to shape public opinion.

An internal crisis forcing Moscow to back down is possible but unlikely. The slow fiscal squeeze will not force Putin's hand; only a sudden shock, such as a major industrial accident, could trigger a crisis that derails the war effort. Both tail risks would emerge unpredictably, and there are few signs of either.

Dramatic Russian escalation beyond Ukraine remains a tail risk. An attack on a Baltic state or a similarly drastic move remains very unlikely: Russia lacks the spare combat power to open a second front while the war continues, and such a move would harden the European resolve Putin hopes to break (see: Escalation between Russia and Ukraine coming in the autumn , 3 September 2026).

There is a 35% chance of a ceasefire in 2027. As escalation over winter is unlikely to improve either side's fundamental position, the first real window for talks since 2022 will open after the first quarter of next year. A deal is far from certain, and many obstacles would have to be resolved. Russia would inevitably have to compromise on some of its hardline political and security demands, and Ukraine would not sign a deal that creates the risk of a subsequent invasion. Even then, President Volodymyr Zelensky would struggle to sell territorial concessions to the public, as US guarantees will remain unreliable and Le Pen would block the carrot of EU membership. Yet war fatigue, growing funding pressures and the threat of another winter would likely soften public opinion (see: EU support for Ukraine at risk from 2028 , 29 October 2026).

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